A PERSONAL DIGITAL SPACE

A 10-page creative direction and implementation specification for redesigning Vikraman V.'s existing portfolio.

PRIMARY EXPERIENCE Sagar Tamang · minimal, personal, editorial	**ENGINEERING LANGUAGE** Karthick A · technical, structured, evidence-led
VISUAL INFLUENCES Japanese editorial minimalism · experimental typography · controlled brutalism	**EXISTING PLATFORM** Next.js · TypeScript · Tailwind · MDX · Vercel

THE DESIGN INTENT

Create a sophisticated, elegant and recognisably personal website. Sagar Tamang should shape the overall browsing experience; Karthick A should shape the engineering archive and project documentation. Japanese editorial principles should guide restraint and composition. Experimental typography and a few brutalist interventions should provide character without sacrificing usability.

This brief is based on the user's 50 design-interview answers and additional preferences. Attach it to Gemini / Google AI Studio alongside the existing repository and reference URLs.

01 / CREATIVE DIRECTION & IDENTITY

The portfolio must communicate sophistication and elegance first. It should feel minimal, but not empty; technical, but not like a dashboard; personal, but not like a diary. The intended impression is an engineer with creative interests: a curious person who builds and explores rather than a generic developer profile.

Four design pillars

- **Editorial minimalism:** spacious composition, strong hierarchy, quiet confidence, deliberate negative space and text-led storytelling.
- **Engineering precision:** accurate metadata, structured project evidence, technical annotations, clear diagrams and thoughtful documentation.
- **Typographic experimentation:** a distinctive serif / sans-serif / monospace system, condensed display moments and unconventional compositions.
- **Controlled brutalism:** sharp divisions, stark contrast, oversized type, asymmetric alignment and large identifiers used selectively.

Reference roles

Sagar Tamang — https://sagartamang.com/
Primary reference for the personal website experience: minimal presentation, homepage composition, typography, whitespace, navigation, personal identity and integration of work and writing.

Karthick A — https://karthick-a.github.io/portfolio/
Primary reference for technical identity: engineering-oriented project catalogue, component identifiers, technical annotations, evidence-led project pages, skills presentation and hardware-inspired details.

Additional references: Geist by Vercel for modern interface typography; Galgo Condensed for condensed editorial display; Humane for expressive typographic character; Dirtyline's 36 Days of Type 2022 for experimental letterform inspiration; Japanese editorial and graphic design for composition and restraint.

The intended balance

Use Sagar's restraint as the foundation and Karthick's engineering language as a selective layer. The website should not look like a mashup of two templates. It must establish its own identity, with different visual intensity on the homepage, archive, project pages, articles, About and Now pages.

The user supplied both sagartamang.com and sagartamag.com in their notes. Verify the intended reference URL before relying on it.

02 / COLOUR, TYPOGRAPHY & COMPOSITION

Develop a completely new palette. Do not treat the previous Obsidian / Bone / Burnt Orange palette as fixed. The desired atmosphere is warm editorial combined with dark technical character. Dark mode is the default.

Colour art direction

- Explore warm near-black, ink, charcoal, graphite and dark mineral tones for the dark theme.
- Explore warm ivory, muted paper, stone and restrained neutral tones for the light theme.
- Select one distinctive accent colour only if it supports the identity. Avoid neon and saturated cyberpunk colours.
- Different pages may use subtle background treatments, but they must share one semantic token system.
- Define background, foreground, surface, elevated surface, muted text, border, accent, focus and interactive-state tokens.
- Verify readable contrast, including small monospaced labels and secondary text. Target WCAG AA where applicable.

Typography is a primary design feature

Use three complementary typographic roles:

- **Expressive serif display:** major editorial headings, selected statements and page titles.
- **Modern sans-serif:** body copy, navigation, descriptions, buttons and general interface text. Investigate Geist by Vercel.
- **Monospaced:** project IDs, dates, tags, metadata, section references, technical annotations and timeline labels.

Investigate Galgo Condensed, Humane and suitable alternatives for display typography. Use Dirtyline's 36 Days of Type 2022 as visual inspiration for experimental letterform composition, not as artwork to reproduce. Verify font availability, licensing, web embedding rights and performance before implementation.

Composition and whitespace

- Use a wide editorial homepage rather than a narrow centred column.
- Vary composition by section: centred, asymmetrical, split and full-width layouts where appropriate.
- Use Japanese design principles such as ma, asymmetrical balance, material sensitivity and intentional negative space.
- Do not use random Japanese characters, stereotypical cultural decorations or kanji as meaningless ornaments.
- Use brutalist elements sparingly: hard dividers, unusual alignment, oversized condensed type, stark contrast and large numerical identifiers.

Avoid generic gradients, neon glows, glassmorphism, random cards, excessive rounded boxes, fake terminal panels, meaningless statistics, decorative clutter and excessive motion.

03 / HOMEPAGE EXPERIENCE

The homepage is a personal digital space, not a résumé summary. It should feel wide, editorial, spacious and text-led. Do not use a personal portrait in the hero.

Navigation

Use a compact text-based editorial navigation with the typographic wordmark and links to Works, About, Now and Contact. Articles must not become a separate primary navigation item. The navigation should disappear while scrolling down and reappear while scrolling upward. The user skipped the exact navigation styling preference; infer a restrained text-based style from their other answers.

Hero

- Introduce Vikraman V. as an Electronics and Communication Engineering student.
- Use first-person, conversational writing. Keep it thoughtful and concise.
- Communicate interests in electronics, software, embedded systems, technology and creative pursuits.
- Avoid generic copy such as 'passionate developer', 'innovative problem solver' and 'building the future'.
- Use a refined serif display heading, sans-serif supporting copy and monospaced metadata.
- Provide Explore Works, a prominent Download Résumé action, GitHub, LinkedIn and Email.
- Do not include a personal portrait or phone number.

Signal-path / waveform illustration

Create an original, restrained signal-path or waveform visual using lightweight SVG or CSS where practical. It may include a waveform, signal nodes, schematic lines or a minimal electronic signal diagram. It should complement the typography rather than become a large 3D object or generic AI technology illustration.

Currently section

Include a very minimal section showing verified current learning, research, building or exploration. Make it easy to update through content or configuration. Do not invent current activities.

Latest project: exactly one

Display exactly ONE project on the homepage. Use a split layout with image on one side and project title, description, date, status and technologies on the other. Select the newest valid project dynamically from existing MDX content using publication dates. Exclude articles. Do not hardcode project names, slugs, descriptions or images. Investigate and fix any existing sorting, filtering or date-parsing bug. A newer project must automatically replace the previous one. Keep older projects accessible in Works. Include an Explore Work link to /work.

Compact personal interests and footer

Add a small personal-interest section mentioning music and guitar, books and reading, cinema and films, and gaming subtly. Do not create a photography section. Do not feature Movies 101 on the homepage. Footer: wordmark, email, GitHub, LinkedIn and copyright. No phone number.

04 / WORKS — PROJECTS & ARTICLES TOGETHER

The Works tab is the single destination for both projects and articles. This is mandatory. Do not create a separate Articles item in the primary navigation.

Archive behaviour

- **All:** display projects and articles together.
- **Projects:** display only project entries.
- **Articles:** display only article entries.
- All filters must work and be keyboard accessible.
- New projects and articles must appear automatically through the existing MDX content system.
- Do not duplicate content in hardcoded React arrays.

Visual language

Use an editorial index as the foundation, with selected Karthick-inspired engineering details. Combine numbered entries, small thumbnails, compact technical metadata, article rows, subtle dividers and occasional image-led project previews. Avoid making every item a large rounded card. Do not make the archive so dense that it becomes difficult to scan.

Project entries

Where available, show project identifier, title, description, date, category, status, technologies and thumbnail. Use the status labels ONGOING, COMPLETED, EXPERIMENTAL and ARCHIVED only when reliable status data exists. Do not invent statuses.

Article entries

Show article title, description, publication date, tags, reading time where reliably calculated and a small thumbnail. Maintain a visual distinction between project and article types without separating them into different destinations.

Routes and content integrity

Projects must open /projects/[slug]. Articles must open /blog/[slug]. Preserve existing slugs, MDX files, publication dates, images, tags and metadata. The existing content model must remain the single source of truth.

The archive should feel like a curated personal index that happens to contain serious technical work and writing. It should not feel like a generic CMS listing page.

05 / PROJECT DETAIL PAGES — ENGINEERING DOCUMENTATION

Project detail pages should carry the strongest Karthick A influence. They should feel like engineering notebooks or technical dossiers, not generic blog posts.

Suggested content structure

1. Project identifier, title and concise overview.
2. Main project image or gallery.
3. Publication date, status, category and technologies.
4. My role and contribution, clearly distinguished from team work.
5. Problem statement and objectives.
6. System architecture and block diagrams.
7. Hardware components and circuit details.
8. Software, firmware and implementation.
9. Schematics, PCB design and supporting visuals where available.
10. Development process, challenges and debugging.
11. Testing, validation and actual results.
12. Lessons learned, GitHub and external resources.
13. Related projects or articles.

Flexible MDX content

Do not force every section into every project. Project content must determine which sections are rendered. Optional frontmatter fields must be backwards-compatible. Existing MDX files must continue to render even when newer metadata is absent.

Technical media support

- Hardware photographs and image galleries.
- Circuit diagrams, schematics and PCB renders.
- Block diagrams and architecture illustrations.
- Code blocks with appropriate syntax highlighting.
- Tables, callouts and technical notes.
- Oscilloscope captures and serial monitor screenshots.
- Videos and downloadable PDFs where provided.

Engineering visual treatment

Use small technical identifiers, monospaced metadata, fine dividers, understated diagram motifs and carefully organised tags. Use the technical visual language to make information clearer, not to decorate empty space.

Accuracy requirements

Never fabricate measurements, component specifications, test results, deployment claims, performance metrics or achievements. For team projects, clearly distinguish what Vikraman personally contributed from what the wider team delivered. Do not overstate professional embedded-systems experience.

06 / ARTICLES, ABOUT & NOW

Articles: technical notebook

Articles remain inside Works, but individual article pages should have a comfortable technical-notebook reading experience. Include title, description, publication date, tags, reading time when reliably calculated, a table of contents for longer articles, readable content width, proper heading hierarchy, images, diagrams, code blocks where relevant, related articles and a Back to Works link.

Technical notes, research-related writing, personal reflections and film writing may coexist. Movies 101 must remain discoverable through the Articles filter inside Works, but must not be featured on the homepage. Do not force every article into a datasheet aesthetic.

About: the person behind the work

The About page should feel personal and thoughtful, not like an extended résumé. Include a concise first-person introduction, academic background, technical interests, areas of exploration, a dedicated skills section, a visual timeline and compact creative interests.

Skills should be grouped into programming, electronics, embedded experimentation, hardware and circuit design, development tools and creative software. Do not use percentage bars, arbitrary proficiency ratings or unsupported skill scores. Demonstrate technical credibility through real projects and evidence.

Timeline

Create a visual academic and project timeline using verified dates and milestones. It should be easy to scan and should not turn every small activity into a major achievement. Use compact monospaced date labels and an editorial visual hierarchy.

Creative interests

Mention music and guitar, books and reading, cinema and films, and gaming subtly. Do not create a dedicated photography section. User-owned photography may be used as supporting imagery where appropriate, but should not become a gallery or a separate photography destination.

Now page: /now

Create a separate /now page. It should feel like a living personal status document rather than a dashboard. Potential categories include currently studying, building, researching, learning and reading. Only populate verified information. Make it easy to update without changing the UI. Keep it personal, simple and consistent with the rest of the site.

07 / WORDMARK, BRUTALISM & INTERACTION

Typographic wordmark

Create a typographic wordmark using the name VIKRAMAN V. Explore condensed typography, elegant serif lettering, monospaced details and custom spacing. It must work in navigation, footer, favicon adaptation, social preview and résumé. Do not create a generic developer logo. Generate favicon and touch-icon assets in suitable sizes, preserving legibility at small dimensions.

Controlled brutalism

Use a few deliberate interventions: oversized condensed headings, hard-edged dividers, unusual alignment, large numbers, stark typographic contrast and cropped compositions. The homepage must remain sophisticated. The Works archive may use stronger contrast. Project pages may use more technical structure. The About page may be more experimental. The Now page should remain simple.

Custom cursor

Implement a subtle custom cursor for desktop only. It may respond gently to interactive elements but must never obstruct content, replace focus indicators or interfere with selection. Disable it on touch devices and fall back to the native cursor when appropriate. Avoid oversized glowing cursor effects.

Scroll and page transitions

Use smooth editorial transitions: gentle section reveals, restrained image movement, typographic transitions and subtle opacity changes. The navigation hides on downward scroll and reappears on upward scroll. Page transitions should use a quick, understated editorial slide or equivalent. Do not delay navigation unnecessarily.

Motion accessibility

Respect prefers-reduced-motion. Essential content must never depend on animation, hover or cursor movement. Provide visible keyboard focus states. Keep the interaction intensity balanced and vary it by page.

No Easter eggs

Do not add hidden interactions, secret shortcuts, surprise animations or Easter eggs. All interface behaviour should be intentional and discoverable.

08 / TECHNICAL INTEGRATION & NON-NEGOTIABLE RULES

Existing application

```
Website: https://byvikraman.me
Repository: https://github.com/V1kraman/portfolio-reimagined
Stack: Next.js App Router, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS, Framer Motion, MDX, shadcn/ui, Lucide and Vercel.
```

Preserve routes

Keep /, /work, /projects/[slug] and /blog/[slug]. Add /now. Preserve existing About and Contact routes if they exist. If they currently appear as homepage sections, decide whether separate pages are justified only after auditing the current structure. Do not create duplicate or unnecessary destinations.

Audit before editing

1. Inspect repository structure and current application architecture.
2. Inspect all MDX files and understand frontmatter schemas.
3. Inspect routing, shared components, layouts and content loaders.
4. Inspect theme tokens, animation utilities and responsive breakpoints.
5. Inspect image assets, metadata, SEO and deployment configuration.
6. Identify the root cause of the missing latest project on the homepage.
7. Map the proposed design to existing code before making changes.

Preserve the content system

- MDX remains the single source of truth.
- Do not duplicate content in hardcoded React arrays or create a second CMS unnecessarily.
- New frontmatter fields must be optional and backwards-compatible.
- Preserve existing content, slugs, images, dates, tags and metadata.
- Do not remove working functionality without a clear reason.

Mandatory content rules

- **Works:** one unified archive containing both projects and articles, with All, Projects and Articles filters.
- **Homepage:** exactly one latest valid project, selected dynamically by publication date; exclude articles and fix the underlying selection bug.
- **Phone:** remove the phone number from every public-facing area, including footer, contact, About, metadata, structured data and hardcoded content. Do not replace it with another number.
- **Accuracy:** never invent achievements, metrics, research findings, project outcomes, skills, current activities or personal contributions.

Responsive and accessible implementation

Design intentionally for desktop, laptop, tablet and mobile. Prevent horizontal overflow. Disable the custom cursor on touch devices. Avoid hover-only content. Preserve keyboard navigation, semantic HTML, contrast, screen-reader labels, reduced motion and readable article widths.

09 / EXECUTION PLAN & ACCEPTANCE

Implementation phases

1. **Reference and code audit:** study both reference websites and inspect the complete existing repository before editing.
2. **Art direction:** establish the new palette, type system, layout grid, spacing, background treatments, technical annotations and brutalist accents.
3. **Shared components:** create or refine navigation, wordmark, buttons, metadata, project and article entries, status labels, galleries, timeline and footer.
4. **Homepage:** implement the editorial hero, signal-path visual, résumé action, minimal Currently section, exactly one latest project and compact personal interests.
5. **Works:** implement the unified projects-and-articles archive with functional filters and MDX-driven content.
6. **Project and article pages:** implement engineering notebook project pages and readable technical notebook articles.
7. **About and Now:** implement the timeline, skills, personal introduction, compact creative interests and separate Now page.
8. **Interaction polish:** implement custom cursor, scroll behaviour, editorial transitions, theme and responsive details.
9. **Validation:** run lint, type checking, production build and route-by-route visual checks. Fix regressions.

Final acceptance checklist

- Sophisticated, elegant, minimal-with-technical-graphics identity.
- Sagar Tamang's personal editorial experience combined with Karthick A's engineering presentation, without copying either.
- New dark-first palette, serif + sans-serif + monospaced typography.
- Japanese editorial composition and restrained brutalist interventions.
- No personal portrait in the hero; original signal-path or waveform visual.
- Compact Currently section and separate /now page.
- Exactly one dynamically selected latest project on homepage.
- Works contains projects and articles, with all three filters functional.
- Project pages support real engineering evidence; articles have a technical notebook reading experience.
- About includes a visual timeline and dedicated skills section.
- No photography section; music in About; gaming subtle; books as a small personal detail; Movies 101 not on homepage.
- Navigation hides on downward scroll and reappears upward; custom cursor is subtle and desktop-only.
- No Easter eggs, phone number, fabricated claims or generic AI design clichés.
- Existing routes and MDX content remain functional; mobile and desktop are polished.

FINAL INSTRUCTION TO GEMINI

Read this entire 10-page brief before editing. Verify the reference URLs. Audit the existing repository and explain how its current architecture maps to the proposed redesign. Then implement the complete redesign directly in the existing application. Do not stop at a mockup, proposal or homepage prototype. Do not replace the application with a new project. Preserve existing content and routes. Run the available lint, type-check and production build commands, test key routes and report the files changed, design decisions, content-schema changes, actual validation results and anything that could not be verified.

The intended result is a sophisticated personal website for an engineer with creative interests: restrained at first glance, technically rich when explored, typographically distinctive and unmistakably Vikraman's.

Prepared from the user's 50-question design interview and additional preferences: Galgo Condensed, Sagar Tamang, Geist by Vercel, Humane, Dirtyline 36 Days of Type 2022, Japanese minimalism and controlled brutalist design.